
ACTOR PART BOOK

Player 3

the youngest, and the curious one

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore · Pirandello, trans. Storer 1922

A Village Players production · Lausanne

Director: **Kiarash Jamshidi**

31 SPEECHES · 369 WORDS ACROSS THE PLAY

WHO PLAYER 3 IS

Player 3 may be played by a young man or a young woman — the part is written for either. These notes use *they*; the director should settle on the pronoun that fits the actor cast, and adjust the few stage directions that carry it.

Carries a handful of the company's small parts — a young romantic turn, the prompt box, and whatever else the morning needs. **In their early twenties — the youngest in the company by a good ten years.** First proper season at the Village Players, after a few small parts last year and a drama school in Geneva that they still mention when they are nervous. They are not yet sure whether they are an actor or a person who is currently acting. **They are also, without question, the happiest person in the building** — they still cannot quite believe they are being paid (a little) to spend their evenings inside a theatre — and they do a bit of everything: prompt from the box, read the small parts, help strike the set, run for the props nobody else will fetch. No job is beneath them, because all of it is theatre, and theatre is the thing they love. The audience reads their age the moment they enter: the body is younger, the listening is sharper, the eyes track the older two to learn what one does.

Their dominant register is *curious*. Where Player 1 has opinions and Player 2 has shoulders, Player 3 has questions. When the Six arrive they are the first to take them seriously — not because they believe the Father's philosophy, but because they have never seen a rehearsal interrupted in this way and they want to know what happens. They lean forward. They nod. They catch themselves nodding and try to stop. The other two notice; they colour. **The notebook is their tell:** they write everything down — lines, phrases, things they do not yet understand but suspect they are meant to keep — and the moment they stop writing is the moment the play has stopped being a curiosity and become something they would rather not have on record.

The arc to score: in Act One they are enthralled by the strangers and slightly embarrassed by their own enthrallment — the one Player who will say out loud that the Father *means* every word, and the one who lets slip, when nervous, the drama school in Geneva they have not yet stopped mentioning. In Act Two they watch the shop-scene replay and stop nodding; the pencil goes still. By Act Three they are the Player who has understood the play the company has stumbled into — the conscience who asks whether someone should stop this, and waits, and is not answered. Their face is the audience's mirror at every horror in the second half.

They take several small turns. The young romantic part is eager and slightly ridiculous — they have been told they have "stage presence" and have heard it as *promise*. In the prompt box they are a young person frowning at the draught and the shorthand, pleased to be useful, faintly aware they are too young for it and trying to compensate with seriousness. The rest are functions: someone has to read a line. They read them clean, no pretension, and look to Player 2 to check they did it right.

The casting note for the audition room: the actor — of any gender — must be young enough that the age difference reads from the back row, and a sharp enough listener that the company's whole second half can be tracked on their face. The audience must believe both that this is the youngest person in the room and that they are the one who understands soonest what the company has stumbled into. That is the role's range.

THE PLAY, AND HOW IT BEGINS

What it is. Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921). A theatre company's ordinary rehearsal is interrupted by six figures — a Father, a Mother, a Step-Daughter, a Son, and two silent children — who claim to be unfinished Characters, abandoned by their author, and demand that their drama be staged. The evening is the collision between their fixed, unbearable story and a working company's attempt to turn it into theatre.

This production. Set in Lausanne, played by **nine live performers** with **two stage objects** in place of the two youngest children (a coat-and-chair for the Boy, a wrapped bundle for the Child), on three stripped settings — **no projection, no screen**. One interval, after Act One; the second half plays unbroken to the fountain.

How it opens. The curtain is already up on a half-lit working stage. The Village Players are dragging themselves into a rehearsal of another Pirandello play, *Mixing It Up* — the Manager arrives tired and behind, there is the business of the cook's cap, the Players bicker. Then the working lights soften to a strange amber: Player 1 carries in the Boy-chair, and the four family Characters walk on, the Step-Daughter already holding the Child-bundle. From that entrance the play has begun, and it does not let go.

HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Everything this role says and does, in performance order, grouped by act and by part. Each speech is preceded by a short **CUE** — the tail of the line before it — so you can find your entrance. Every line has a single named speaker, so there is never any doubt which of you speaks. Blocking lives in the bracketed action cues inside the speeches. The text is pulled byte-for-byte from the Director's Copy, so it always matches the current script.

Act One — The Family

PART I *The Rehearsal*

3 SPEECHES · 77 WORDS

The **PLAYERS** of the company enter from the back of the stage: first one, then another, then the third; three in all. They are about to rehearse a Pirandello play: *Mixing it Up*. [*Il giuoco delle parti.*] Some of the company move off towards their dressing rooms. **PLAYER 3** who has the "book" under his arm, is waiting for the manager in order to begin the rehearsal.

Finally, the **MANAGER** enters with the precise weariness of a man who has been managing the Village Players for too long. He goes to the table prepared for him. **PLAYER 3** brings him his mail, through which he glances with the expression of one who has never, in his life, received good news from an envelope. **PLAYER 3** takes his seat, turns on a light, and opens the "book."

CUE *Player 1:* ... public came back for the third act once. I was in it.

PLAYER 3 [*reading the "book"*]. "Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study."

CUE *Player 2:* Red set. Same flats as the blue room. I'll turn them round.

PLAYER 3 [*reading from the "book"*]. "When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, dressed in cook's cap and apron is busy beating an egg in a cup. Philip, also dressed as a cook, is beating another egg. Guido Venanzi is seated and listening."

CUE *Player 1:* Let the record show that I wear it under protest.

PLAYER 3. Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door they still haven't mended, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

PART II *The Interruption*

13 SPEECHES · 183 WORDS

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.

PLAYER 3 [*coming forward from the others*]. Oh — do you hear that?

CUE *The Father:* ... woman. So one may also be born a character in a play.

PLAYER 3 [*softly, to Player 2*]. Sorry — is this still the rehearsal?

CUE *Player 2:* ... all down, and we'll work out later which half was the play.

PLAYER 3 [*doing exactly that, in a small notebook*]. I *am* writing it all down. I've got "born a character in a play." I don't know what it means yet — but it seemed like the sort of thing one is meant to keep.

CUE *The Father:* No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

PLAYER 3. Just listen to him. Honestly — just listen. I came in for a Tuesday rehearsal, and there is a man on our stage who means every word he says. When did anyone here last mean a word?

| **CUE** *Player 1:* Speak for yourself. I have room.

PLAYER 3 [*pointing to the STEP-DAUGHTER*]. I've no objection, as far as that one is concerned!

| **CUE** *Player 2:* Well done!

PLAYER 3. Encore!

| **CUE** *The Father:* Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

PLAYER 3. Is it true?

| **CUE** *Player 2:* We are the audience this time.

PLAYER 3 [*quietly, the pencil not moving*]. For once. [*Nobody laughs.*]

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... and you hear another? We think we understand. We never really do.

PLAYER 3 [*a whisper to Player 1*]. I understood words. I'm fairly confident about words.

| **CUE** *The Manager:* Of course, of course; but let's hear them out.

PLAYER 3 [*the most earnest of the three, genuinely curious*]. This is something quite new. I have not seen anything quite like this before.

| **CUE** *Player 3:* ... something quite new. I have not seen anything quite like this before.

PLAYER 3 [*dropping the role, lower, to Player 2 — nervous, fast*]. We did Pirandello at the school in Geneva. Two scenes, in a basement, badly. I keep thinking — this is what it was supposed to feel like, and nobody ever told us.

| **CUE** *The Father:* ... is the way we tell each other: blind yourself, because I have.

PLAYER 3 [*low, to Player 1*]. Is anyone else following this? At all?

| **CUE** *Player 1:* ... I am nodding, and so should you. Nodding is half the craft.

PLAYER 3 [*nodding — then catching themselves nodding, and stopping*]. I'm following some of it. I'm just not sure I want to follow the rest. That's new for me as well.

PART III *The Bargain*

3 SPEECHES · 15 WORDS

| **CUE** *Player 1:* ... six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.

PLAYER 3. They are not ordinary strangers.

| **CUE** *Player 2:* He once staged the Nativity in fifteen.

PLAYER 3. Perhaps there is a play.

| **CUE** *Player 1:* They looked expected.

PLAYER 3. Am I taking this down?

Act Two — The Theatre

PART I *The Setup*

7 SPEECHES · 40 WORDS

CUE *The Son*: ... apart from that idea of father and mother which we give them?

PLAYER 3 [*very quietly, the pencil gone still in their hand*]. *Mon Dieu*. I've stopped writing it down. I don't want a record of this one.

PLAYER 1 runs off at once to prepare the scene, and arranges it while THE MANAGER talks with PLAYER 2 and PLAYER 3 on matters of detail.

PLAYER 2 hurries off to obey his orders. While she is putting the things in their places, the MANAGER talks to PLAYER 3 and then with the CHARACTERS and the other PLAYERS.

CUE *The Manager*: ... I'm going to ask you to do something out of the ordinary.

PLAYER 3 [*looking up from the book; an unusual request to receive at this hour*]. Take it down in shorthand? Sir — *in shorthand*?

CUE *The Manager*: Exactly! Can you do shorthand?

PLAYER 3. Yes, a little.

CUE *Player 2*: Why?

PLAYER 3. Our hats?

CUE *Player 2*: Only the mantle?

PLAYER 3. He must be mad.

CUE *Player 1*: But why?

PLAYER 3. Mantles as well?

CUE *Player 1*: There you are!

PLAYER 3. This is really funny.

PART II *The Apparition*

2 SPEECHES · 18 WORDS

CUE *Player 1*: What's going to happen next? Have we lost the script entirely?

PLAYER 3. Where does *she* come from? Not from the SSA list, I can tell you that.

CUE *Player 1*: What does she say? Madame — speak up.

PLAYER 3. Louder! Louder please!

PART III *The Substitution*

PLAYER 3 DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

Act Three — The Question

PART I *The Trap*

PLAYER 3 DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

PART II *The Refusal*

1 SPEECH · 20 WORDS

CUE *The Father:* ... life. We've all tried him in turn — I, she and she.

PLAYER 3 *[to no one in particular — the youngest voice in the room].* Should we — should someone — stop this? I keep waiting for one of you to say that we should. *[No one does.]*

PART III *The Fountain*

2 SPEECHES · 16 WORDS

PLAYER 2 and PLAYER 3 at this point separate themselves from the group of PLAYERS. One watches the MOTHER attentively; the other moves about studying the movements and manner of the SON whom he will have to act.

CUE *The Son:* What do you want?

PLAYER 3. Nothing! I was just looking at you.

CUE *Player 2:* Dead!

PLAYER 3. No, no, it's only make believe, it's only pretence!